In order to work the steps we need a close working relationship with our individual NA sponsors. Besides offering help and guidance on addiction issues in our personal lives, sponsors' share their experience, hope and faith as they help guide us through the 12 steps of Narcotics Anonymous.

Working the steps also requires regular attendance at a weekly NA step meeting. This is an "I can't, we can" recovery program, and we can learn a lot by listening to other recovering addicts share their experiences working the 12 steps.

What follows are some suggestions for working the steps based on the experiences of other recovering addicts. For most of us, working the steps involves writing on each one, sharing what we've written with our sponsors, and living each step to the best of our ability.

Keep in mind there are no right or wrong answers to be looked up in the back of a textbook or teacher's guide. These are suggestions to help us understand how to work the Twelve Steps of Narcotics Anonymous. Our ideas about the steps change as we work them. In living the steps we seek, progress, not perfection.

Step One

1. What is the dictionary definition of "powerless?"
2. How was my life powerless during active drug addiction?
3. How was I powerless over my drug use?
4. How did powerlessness extend into other, areas like work, finances, relationships, family, etc.?
5. What are three good examples of how my life was unmanageable?
6. How does powerlessness apply in those areas?
7. What are reservations and how are they dangerous to my recovery?
8. How is my life unmanageable in my recovery (physically, emotionally and spiritually)?
9. What are the symptoms of my addiction?
10. What are the the benefits of accepting my powerlessness over my addiction?
11. What are the benefits of surrendering the management of my life to Narcotics Anonymous?
12. Is willpower enough to stop using drugs? Explain.
13. How is surrender another word for victory in the NA program?
14. How do I try to control situations to prevent feeling powerless?
15. How is addiction a progressive and incurable disease?

16. How is being self-centered in conflict with spiritual growth?

17. How have denial, substitution, rationalization, justification, distrust of others, guilt, embarrassment, dereliction, isolation, and loss of control been a part of my life?

18. What does being responsible for my recovery mean?

19. Is drug use a symptom of my addiction? Are drugs the primary problem, or does the problem lie within me in the form of a physical, emotional and spiritual disease that makes me crave drugs? Explain.

20. What does "we" mean? Define "fellowship."

21. What does "I can't ever get my life together" mean?

Step Two

1. How did I come to believe in a higher power?

2. What part does willingness play in coming to believe?

3. How did insanity apply during my active drug addiction?

4. How do I see my higher power helping to restore me to sanity?

5. What are the characteristics of a power greater than myself?

6. What is my definition of insanity?

7. How am I insane in my recovery?

8. What are five instances where a power greater than myself has helped me in my life?

9. What does "can restore us to sanity" mean?

10. What are examples of a power greater than myself during my active addiction?

11. How do I develop a working relationship with my higher power?

12. What is the NA definition of insanity and how does that apply to me?

13. How do I learn to trust in a higher power?

14. What does "acting as if" mean?

15. It is suggested that my higher power be loving and caring. Explain.

16. What is the difference between spirituality and religion?

17. How is "coming to believe" a process?

18. Should my higher power love me? Explain.

19. How is Step Two necessary if I expect to achieve an ongoing recovery?

Step Three

1. How did I decide to turn my life and will over to the care of God?

2. How is this decision reflected in my prayers?

3. Define "care of God."

4. What does "we made a decision" mean?

5. What effect does my will have in my life?

6. What does it mean to turn my life and will "over to the care of?"

7. What is my understanding of God?

8. What are some examples of how I was unsuccessful in running my own life?

9. What does it mean to "turn it over?"

10. List examples of God's will versus self-will.

11. What are the results of turning my life and will over to the care of God as I understand Him?

12. What are the changes in my life when I turn my life and will over to the care of God?

13. What would happen to my life if I really "let go and let God?"

14. How does the decision to take Step Three help me to experience personal growth and freedom?

15. How does taking this step help me to become more responsible in my life?

16. What are some areas in my life where I find it easy to turn my life and will over to the care of God?

17. In what areas of my life do I find it hard to turn my life and will over to the care of God?

18. What are some of my fears of "turning my life and will over?"

19. If surrender means powerlessness over my addiction in Step One, what does surrender mean in Step Three?

Step Four

A strong faith and willingness is necessary for Step Four. It is very important to have a basic understanding of Steps One through Three and to remember that what we write is between us and our Higher Power -- a Higher Power who loves and cares for us.

Keeping Step Four separate from Step Five also is necessary. If we think of the eventual sharing while working Step Four, we may not write honestly and freely. If the inventory is no longer searching and fearless, we rob ourselves of the benefits of this step. It is helpful to remember that we all are human and are not all bad. In Step Four we are not confessing how horrible we are, so we must write on our assets as well as our liabilities. Our Fourth Step doesn't have to be perfect. Recovery is a process, not perfection.

1. What does "searching and fearless" mean?
2. What is a moral inventory?
3. What is the purpose of doing a moral inventory?
4. Do I have any reservations about doing this step? If so, what are they?
5. Where am I at with faith today?
6. What are the advantages of doing a Step Four inventory?
7. How is writing out this step important?
8. How is it important to work Steps One through Three before doing this step?
9. It is suggested that I refrain from going back over my Fourth Step inventory while writing it. Explain.
10. How will knowing my self-destructive patterns help me?
11. How is fear a major obstacle in working this step?

Step Five

1. What does "we admitted" mean?
2. In this step it is suggested that we admit past wrong doings three times -- to God, another person and ourselves. Explain.
3. What does "the exact nature of our wrongs" mean?
4. What do I think the benefits of this step will be?
5. What are important characteristics to keep in mind when choosing a person to share this step?

6. How will completing Step Five help break my isolation?

7. What relief will I get from sharing my secrets?

8. What harm will come if I don't share?

9. What spiritual principles are to be learned from working this step?

10. How is it important to share without reservation?

11. It is suggested that I take Step Five soon after completing Step Four. Explain.

12. How can I get over the fear of being judged while doing this step?

13. What is my definition of humility?

14. How is it important for me to admit my feelings in Step Five?

15. What does "We are only as sick as our secrets" mean?

Step Six

1. What is a defect of character?

2. Make a list of all character defects and give a strong example of each one.

3. This is a step of willingness. Explain.

4. What does "entirely ready" mean?

5. How do I become entirely ready?

6. Am I entirely ready to have God remove all my defects of character at this time? If so, why? If not, why not?

7. How important is the knowledge that God will remove my defects?

8. How is humility involved in working this step?

9. What is this step asking me to do?

10. The NA recovery text says "our defects drain us of all our time and energy." Explain.

11. How does self-will destroy any hope of working this step?

12. How do I act out on my defects in my life?

13. What purpose do they serve?

14. What would my life be like without character defects?

15. How does Step Six open the door to freedom of self?

16. How does Step Six deepen my surrender to my higher power?

17. Do I trust God enough to surrender all my character defects to Him?

18. If I have decided to turn my life and will over to the care of God as I understand Him, why would I hesitate to let go of character defects that would hinder my recovery?

19. How is holding onto character defects detrimental to me and my recovery?

20. How is a return to sanity achieved by removal of character defects?

21. This step says that God will remove my defects of character. Explain.

22. How is fear at the base of many of my character defects?

23. Do I want to change and grow?

24. How necessary is complete surrender?

25. How does this step help me to see my "humanness?"

26. How will I know when it's time to move on to Step Seven?

Step Seven

1. What is the difference between a defect and a shortcoming?

2. I must be the one who decides to have God remove all of my defects of character. Explain.

3. How will my behavior change with the removal of my character defects?

4. How does prayer apply to this step?

5. What does it mean to "humbly ask?"

6. What is humility?

7. How do I develop humility?

8. I must ask rather than tell or demand God to remove my defects. Explain.

9. How am I denying the power of God in my life by denying my strengths of character?

10. How is losing faith dangerous to my recovery?

11. It is sometimes suggested that Step Seven is best worked by "acting the opposite." What does this mean and how will it help?

12. List the character strengths that are the direct opposite of the defects listed in Step Six.

13. How is this is an action step?

14. How is it helpful for me to listen when a fellow addict points out one of my character defects?

15. How can I humble myself before my higher power?

16. What is the importance of accepting the character defects of others?

17. Do I realize that I cannot remove my own shortcomings?

18. How important is it for me to share about my shortcomings with others?

19. Explain how willingness and faith are important with this step.

20. How can I take the necessary action to work this step?

21. What is the difference between humility and humiliation?

22. It is suggested that I identify instead of compare. How is comparing dangerous when working this step?

23. How is it helpful to keep in mind that God will remove my character defects on His time and not on mine?

24. How will I know when it's time to move on to Step Eight?

Step Eight

1. What is the importance of making a list of those I have harmed in the past?

2. Who should be on my list?

3. Where do I get the names from?

4. Should my list also include myself? my Higher Power? people who are deceased?

5. Is there a limit to how many names should be on the list?

6. What was the exact nature of my wrongs to the people on my list?

7. What is the importance of honesty when working this step?

8. What will happen if I avoid this step?

9. How does rationalizing my wrongs prevent me from working this step?

10. How can looking ahead to Step Nine sabotage Step Eight?

11. How is working closely with my sponsor important when I work this step?

12. I must become willing before this step will have any effect. Explain.

13. How is thoroughness important when I work this step?

14. This step says I should list all persons and not some persons. Explain.

15. What is the importance of practicing Step Seven before working this step?

16. What is the spiritual principle of Step Eight?

17. I should not have expectations when working this step. Explain.

18. How is a positive attitude valuable in working this step?

19. How are faith and self-forgiveness important when working this step?

20. It is important to look only at the part I played in past wrong-doings when working this step. Explain.

21. How is coming to terms with the fact that I am not a victim important when working this step?

22. What is the importance of making a separate list of financial amends?

Step Nine

1. How important is letting go of the outcome when working this step?

2. How is it helpful not to have expectations and to leave the results up to God when working this step?

3. What are indirect amends? Give examples where indirect amends are appropriate.

4. How can I make amends to people who aren't alive?

5. How does "except when to do so would injure them or others" apply when I work this step?

6. Under what circumstances might I be included among the "others?"

7. How is it helpful for me to rely on professional financial and legal assistance when making financial amends?

8. What are "amends?"

9. What is the importance of working with my sponsor when I work this step?

10. How does working the previous eight steps thoroughly prepare me for working this step?

11. What is the danger of making amends to people who still are using drugs?

12. How does working this step help me to live in the present?

13. What happens if I avoid taking action in Step Nine?

14. How do pride, fear and procrastination get in my way when I work this step?

15. What are the benefits of making direct amends?

16. How are patience and humility helpful in working this step?

17. What kind of spiritual growth results from working this step?

18. How will I know when I've finished Step Nine?

19. What is the dictionary definition of "freedom?"

20. Are freedom and responsibility gifts I receive from taking action with this step? Explain.

Step Ten

1. Study the NA Tenth Step I.P., "Living The Program."

2. What is the purpose of taking a personal inventory?

3. What is the spiritual principle of Step Ten?

4. Have I hurt myself or another person today?

5. How will it help me to work closely with my sponsor when I begin to work this step?

6. How does this step help me to live just for today?

7. When conducting a personal inventory, are any areas I shy away from are the areas that need the most attention?

8. How does the statement, "we must change or die" apply to me?

9. It is suggested that I promptly admit my wrongs. Explain.

10. How can working this step prevent my defects from regaining control of my life?

11. How does admitting when I'm wrong allow for personal growth?

12. How is faith a remedy for fear when I work this step?

13. What is the importance of rigorous honesty in working this step?

14. What are the benefits of working this step?

15. What does "we have the right not to feel miserable" mean?

16. "If we do not stay aware of our defects, they can drive us into a corner we cannot get out of clean." What does this statement mean to me?

17. How does this step free me from the wreckage of the present?

18. What does emotional pain have to do with this step?

19. How does admitting I was wrong deflate my ego?

20. How are personal inventories helpful even when I'm feeling good?

21. How does reminding myself that I'm not perfect help me work this step?

22. How does this step allow me to be myself?

23. What do I do when I see a pattern in the amends I make on a regular basis?

24. What do I do when I find myself unable to make amends promptly when they are required?

25. This step does not specify daily inventory but it's still suggested. Explain.

26. How does a daily inventory make my life easier?

27. Is it necessary to write this inventory, or can it be done mentally or verbally?

28. What is the outcome if I do not promptly admit and make amends when I'm wrong?

29. How are spot check inventories helpful?

30. How is it helpful to remember the good things that happen during the day and things I'm grateful for when conducting a daily inventory?

Step Eleven

1. What is prayer?
2. What is meditation?
3. What is the difference between prayer and meditation?
4. What does "quiet the mind" mean and how do I do it?
5. What is meant by the statement, "as long as our spiritual needs are met, our living problems are reduced to a point of comfort?"
6. Should I pray only when I'm hurting? when I want something?
7. How often should I pray?
8. What is "conscious contact?"
9. How does this step help me grow spiritually?
10. What is praying "only for the knowledge of His will?"
11. Look up the word "only" in the dictionary.
12. How is it helpful to use spontaneous prayer throughout the day?
13. How might it be helpful to have a special spot where I go and meditate?
14. How does this step help me face life on life's terms?
15. How is it beneficial for me to pray to God in my own words?
16. How does prayer help me place things in perspective?
17. What is my understanding of the Serenity Prayer?
18. When I pray to God I'm talking; when I meditate I'm listening. What does this mean to me?
19. How does God help me through people?
20. What does God-reliant mean?
21. What does surrender mean in Step Eleven?
22. Why must I surrender my control?

23. How does it help to remember that this is a spiritual and not a religious program?

24. How do character defects prevent me from working this step?

25. What role does faith play in this step?

26. How can fear rob me of the benefits of this step?

27. How does keeping an open mind help me work this step?

28. How may the results of meditation show themselves in my life?

29. Is this step the spiritual basis I need to experience a spiritual awakening, practice spiritual principles, and carry a strong message to attract others to recovery? Explain.

30. What does "the power to carry it out" mean?

31. What does being responsible for my prayers mean?

32. How is the "urgency to take care of things" absent when I work this step?

Step Twelve

1. How does this step open me up to living?

2. How does working the steps teach me to accept life?

3. How does working this step help me to put love and commitment into action?

4. What is the meaning behind the expression, "when all else fails, work with another addict?"

5. What are different ways of carrying the message of Narcotics Anonymous?

6. How is sponsorship a two-way street?

7. How is it helpful for me to be aware of my powerlessness when I do service work?

8. What are the spiritual principles behind the suggestion that men sponsor men and women sponsor women?

9. What is the message I carry?

10. What spiritual principles am I practicing?

11. What is a spiritual awakening?

12. What part does change play in this step?